	COMPLAINT AND APPEALS HANDLING PROCEDURE	
	Document no: ASMF 7.18B	
Compiled by:	**Sifiso Nyambi - Laboratory Manager**	
Approved by:	**Nonhlanhla Msibi - Operations Manager**	

Extension of Application – ISO/IEC 17025 Activities

In addition to proficiency testing and certified reference material activities, this procedure shall also apply to complaints and/or appeals arising from testing, calibration, sampling, reporting of results, and customer service activities conducted under ISO/IEC 17025 accreditation.

This includes, but is not limited to, complaints or appeals relating to:

- Test or calibration results
- Sampling activities
- Method selection or application
- Report content or interpretation
- Turnaround times
- Staff conduct or competence
- Alleged nonconformities with ISO/IEC 17025 requirements

Additional Responsibilities (ISO/IEC 17025 Context)

Laboratory Manager:

- Ensures compliance with ISO/IEC 17025 clauses 7.9 (Complaints), 7.10 (Nonconforming Work), and 8.5 (Actions to Address Risks and Opportunities).
- Ensures records of complaints and appeals are maintained and retrievable.

Technical Manager/ Laboratory Supervisor:

- Provides technical input into investigations relating to test/calibration validity.
- Confirms whether reported results may be affected and determines the need for result recall or re-issue.

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Additional Procedure – ISO/IEC 17025 Complaints and Appeals Handling

1. Receipt and Logging

- All complaints and/or appeals relating to ISO/IEC 17025 laboratory activities shall be received in writing and recorded in the complaints register.
- The complainant shall be informed of receipt of the complaint and the process to be followed.

2. Review and Classification

- The Laboratory Manager/Supervisor shall confirm whether the complaint or appeal relates to:
  a) PT/CRM activities, or
  b) ISO/IEC 17025 testing, calibration, or sampling activities.
- Where related to ISO/IEC 17025, the matter shall also be evaluated as potential nonconforming work.

3. Investigation

- An investigator independent of the activity being complained about shall be appointed where practicable.
- Evidence shall be collected, including but not limited to:
  - Test/calibration records
  - Instrument logs and calibration status
  - Method validation/verification records
  - Environmental monitoring records
  - Staff training and competence records
  - Customer communications

4. Technical Impact Assessment

- The Technical Manager shall assess whether the validity of reported results is affected.

Effective date	Rev status	Next review date
01/2026	00	01/2029

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- Where results are found to be invalid or questionable:
  - The customer shall be notified in writing.
  - Amended or withdrawn reports shall be issued where required.
  - Re-testing or re-sampling shall be considered where feasible.

5. Decision and Corrective Action

- The Laboratory Manager/Supervisor shall determine whether the complaint or appeal is valid.
- Root cause analysis shall be performed where applicable.
- Corrective and/or preventive actions shall be documented and implemented in accordance with the corrective action procedure.

6. Communication of Outcome

- The official outcome of the investigation shall be communicated to the complainant in writing.
- Where applicable, this shall include:
  - Explanation of findings
  - Actions taken
  - Any impact on previously reported results

7. Impartiality and Confidentiality

- All complaints and appeals shall be handled impartially and without discrimination.
- Personnel involved in the original activity shall not decide on the outcome of the complaint where resources allow.
- Confidentiality of the complainant and related records shall be maintained.

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8. Risk-Based Thinking

- Complaints and appeals related to ISO/IEC 17025 activities shall be reviewed for potential risks to result validity, customer confidence, and accreditation compliance.
- Identified risks shall be logged in the risk register and managed in accordance with the risk management procedure.

Records (ISO/IEC 17025 Context)

The following records shall be retained:

- Complaint/appeal register entries
- Investigation reports
- Corrective action records
- Customer communications
- Revised or withdrawn test/calibration reports (if applicable)

All records shall be controlled in accordance with the document and record control procedure.

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